

A Himalayan

The political instability in Nepal is a severe test for its nascent democracy and poses a major diplomatic challenge for India

CRISIS

| By Saurabh Shukla with Soni Sangwan in Kathmandu |

It's a scary scenario. In the middle of a divisive election, India's neighbourhood is on fire. Even as South Block keeps a wary eye on developments in Sri Lanka and Pakistan, last week's collapse of the Nepal government led by prime minister Pushp Kamal Dahal, better known as Prachanda, adds another dimension to the diplomatic challenges that the new government in South Block will face. The Nepal crisis is the most urgent. The resignation of the eight-month-old Maoist government has thrown Nepal's nascent democracy into a state of chaos, and with it, increased the threat to India's security considering the long, open border between the two countries. The final act began last week when the battle lines were drawn between Army Chief General Rookmangud Katawal and Prachanda's government, a relationship already frayed over the issue of absorbing former

Maoist rebels from the People's Liberation Army (PLA) into the Nepal Army. The PLA and the then Royal Nepal Army had fought bloody battles in the past. The tipping point was the army chief's differences with defence minister Ram Prasad Thapa alias Badal, known for his pro-Beijing views. Katawal, a graduate from the Indian Military Academy, had balked at the idea of saluting a defence minister who was a former member of the PLA.

What brought the stalemate to a head was the seemingly trivial issue of the National Games. The Nepalese Army contingent at the games refused to participate when they were confronted with the fait accompli of playing against a new team of the former PLA cadre. With Prachanda demanding Katawal's resignation, the crisis deepened and turned into a diplomatic game between the two sides with big stakes in Nepal, India and China.

Katawal approached Indian Ambassador Rakesh Sood and New Delhi tried to mediate. A compromise was reached and at one stage it was even accepted by the Maoists, but they reneged because, diplomatic sources say, Chinese diplomats in Kathmandu told them to stick to their guns and announce the appointment of Lt-General Khadka as the new army chief. Insiders say that the plan was that Khadka would return the favour by appointing the head of the Maoist PLA, Nanada Kishor Pun alias Pasang, to the post of Lt-general, who would then be elevated to chief of army after Khadka's retirement in two months.

But while the backroom games were going on, Prachanda pushed through a cabinet decision to dismiss Katawal and got the official letter issued through the chief secretary. What he had probably not bargained for was that President Ram Baran Yadav would oppose him, reinstating the army chief. And when the government's coalition partners, too, backed out, Prachanda decided to make the grand gesture of resigning, throwing the country into another round of turmoil. In Kathmandu, Maoist supporters have been holding massive rallies opposing the move, with many blaming India for the outcome. In Nepal, as in Pakistan and Sri Lanka, India is the favourite whipping boy. New Delhi, however, has reasons to be worried. Prachanda, despite his Maoist leanings, is very much indebted to India since he had been allowed to stay in a safe house in Delhi while he was a wanted man in Nepal under the monar-



**MAOIST SUPPORTERS
AT A PROTEST RALLY
IN KATHMANDU**

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